

Xeric Hammock On the dry, ancient dunes where fire has been kept at bay, a shady forest of **sand live oaks** establishes a "green silence." The closed canopy creates a cool, leaf-littered refuge that holds moisture in the soil, offering a respite from the "bone-dry" heat of the surrounding scrub.

Where to see it: Explore the oak domes within the **Citrus Tract of the Withlacoochee State Forest** to the north, or the ridges of **Highlands Hammock State Park** to the east.

Wet Prairie This is an open, sun-filled expanse where the pines thin out and the ground remains soggy, though rarely flooded. It is a landscape of intense diversity, where carnivorous **pitcher plants** and orchids thrive in the nutrient-poor, fire-swept soil, waiting for the "pulse" of the rainy season.

Where to see it: Witness the sheet flow across the landscape at **Myakka River State Park** or the vast flats of **Kissimmee Prairie Preserve**

Wet Flatwoods A pine forest with wet feet, where the water table sits just below the surface, supporting a canopy of **slash** or **pond pine**. Here, the vegetation must tolerate both the soak of the wet season and the scorch of the dry, fostering a rich groundcover of **wiregrass** and **fetterbush**.

Where to see it: Wander the pine islands at **Myakka River State Park** or the **Starkey Wilderness Park** to the north.

Upland Pine On the rolling red-clay hills, widely spaced **longleaf pines** stand over a diverse carpet of **wiregrass** and wildflowers. This high ground is maintained by the regular "cleansing" of fire, which prevents hardwoods from choking out the light and maintains the open savanna.

Where to see it: This community is rare this far south; travel north to the **Withlacoochee State Forest** or the **Goethe State Forest** to walk these clay-hill cathedrals.

Upland Mixed Woodland A sun-dappled woodland where **longleaf pines** and **southern red oaks** share the canopy in an open, park-like setting. It is a landscape of balance, maintained by frequent fires that keep the understory clear and allow the grasses and legumes to flourish in the transition between hill and hammock.

Where to see it: Visit the ecotones between sandhills and hardwoods at **San Felasco Hammock Preserve State Park** (north of the region) for the best example of this transitional landscape.

Upland Hardwood Forest A stately, closed-canopy forest where diverse hardwoods like **southern magnolia** and **pignut hickory** create deep shade and rich leaf litter. Protected from fire, the trees grow tall in the fertile soil, creating a cool, mesic environment that feels older and more permanent than the shifting pine lands.

Where to see it: Walk the shaded trails of the **Withlacoochee State Forest** to experience this climax community.

Shell Mound These hills are the echoes of ancient civilizations, built entirely of discarded shells that now support a unique forest of calcium-loving plants. Rising from the coast, they offer a tropical refuge on a substrate created by human hands centuries ago.

Where to see it: Climb the ancient refuse of history at **Madira Bickel Mound State Archaeological Site** overlooking Terra Ceia Bay.

Scrubby Flatwoods A tension zone between the moist flatwoods and the dry scrub, where scattered pines stand over a thicket of **scrub oaks** and **saw palmetto**. Here, the plants must tolerate both the wet and the dry, existing on the sandy rises of the flatlands.

Where to see it: Explore the transition zones at **Starkey Wilderness Park** or **Balm Boyette Scrub** in Hillsborough County.

Scrub On these ancient, bone-dry dunes, life is stunted and twisted by the scarcity of water and nutrients. It is a harsh, "elfin" forest of **scrub oaks** and **Florida rosemary** that endures long periods of silence before being renewed by intense, stand-replacing fire.

Where to see it: See the ancient sand dunes at **Balm Boyette Scrub**, **Starkey Wilderness Park**, or the **Cedar Key Scrub** to the north.

Sandhill Rolling hills of deep, ancient sand support widely spaced **longleaf pines** and **turkey oaks**. It is a sun-washed savanna kept open by frequent fire, where the **wiregrass** holds the sugar-sand in place.

Where to see it: Visit the rolling high ground of the **Citrus Tract in Withlacoochee State Forest** to see the longleaf pines standing over wiregrass.

Salt Marsh A vast, open expanse of **cordgrass** and **needle rush** that drinks the tide twice a day. This is the "liquid land" where the boundary between earth and ocean dissolves, fueling the estuary with the energy of decomposition.

Where to see it: While much was lost to development, fringes remain along **Tampa Bay**, or visit the vast expanses at the **Lower Suwannee National Wildlife Refuge** to the north

Pine Rockland A jagged, rocky terrain where **South Florida slash pines** root directly into the eroded limestone. This is a fire-dependent garden of tropical shrubs and wildflowers, thriving on the sun-baked rock where few other forests could survive.

Where to see it: You will not find this rock-bound forest near Tampa; you must travel south to **Long Pine Key** in the Everglades or **Big Pine Key** to see the slash pines rooting in limestone

Mesic Hammock Islands of cool shade in a landscape of sun, these forests of **live oak** and **cabbage palm** develop where fire cannot reach. The dense canopy retains moisture, creating a stable, evergreen sanctuary for ferns and air plants.

Where to see it: Walk beneath the closed canopy at **Highlands Hammock State Park** to the east or the **Little Big Econ State Forest**.

Mesic Flatwoods The quintessential Florida landscape, where tall pines cast long shadows over a floor of **saw palmetto** and **wiregrass**. It is a system built on fire; without the cleansing flames, the open, sun-drenched diversity would be lost to the shadows of encroaching hardwoods.

Where to see it: Wander the open pine savannas of **Starkey Wilderness Park** or **Myakka River State Park**.

Maritime Hammock On old, stabilized dunes protected from the immediate salt spray, a canopy of **live oak** and **cabbage palm** creates a cool, shady refuge. This forest is sculpted by the wind, its low profile a testament to the shaping power of the sea breeze.

Where to see it: Accessible only by boat, the wind-pruned trees of **Cayo Costa State Park** or **Anclote Key** guard the barrier islands.

Mangrove Swamp A "walking forest" that straddles the boundary between land and sea, trapping sediments in a tangle of prop roots. It is a quiet, horizontal world where falling leaves fuel a rich aquatic soup, protecting the coast by absorbing the energy of the tides.

Where to see it: Paddle through the "walking trees" at **Charlotte Harbor Preserve State Park** to the south or along the protected fringes of **Tampa Bay**

Hydric Hammock A shady, humid forest of oaks and **cabbage palms** where the limestone lies just beneath the surface. It occupies the wet margins, surviving occasional floods and protecting the interior with a dense, evergreen canopy that rarely burns.

Where to see it: Experience this wet forest along the **Lower Hillsborough River Flood Detention Area** or at **Waccasassa Bay Preserve**.

Floodplain Swamp In the dark, flooded backwaters of the river, buttressed **cypress** and **tupelo** trees stand in the tea-colored current. This is a water-bound forest that thrives on the nutrient pulse of the flood, a slow-moving filter for the river system.

Where to see it: Drift through the dark waters of the **Withlacoochee River** to see the buttressed cypress knees.

Floodplain Marsh Along the river's edge, the forest gives way to open ribbons of **sawgrass** and **cordgrass** that rise and fall with the flowing water. These marshes are the river's breathing room, absorbing the floods and offering a rich, shifting mosaic of habitat for wading birds.

Where to see it: Watch the river of grass expand at **Myakka River State Park**.

Dry Prairie A vast, sweeping horizon of **wiregrass** and **saw palmetto** where the sky touches the earth without interruption. It is a landscape maintained by the twin forces of fire and flood, too wet for pines but too dry for the marsh, existing in a perpetual state of renewal.

Where to see it: The vast, treeless horizons of **Myakka River State Park** offer one of the last glimpses of this sweeping landscape.

Dome Swamp A circular cathedral of **cypress** trees, growing taller toward the center where the peat is deep and the water still. It is a reservoir for the landscape, surviving on the delicate balance between the flood that feeds it and the fire that keeps it open.

Where to see it: Look for these cypress circles in the flatwoods of **Withlacoochee State Forest** or **Three Lakes Wildlife Management Area**.

Depression Marsh A small, rounded window into the water table, where concentric rings of grasses mark the slow retreat of the water. These shallow ephemeral ponds are the "gator holes" of the flatwoods, fostering a burst of aquatic life before drying down to wait for the rain.

Where to see it: Visit **Archbold Biological Station** to the southeast to see these ephemeral ponds dotting the scrub.

Coastal Strand Smoothed by the salt spray, this community of tough shrubs acts as a living windbreak along the coast. It survives by bending to the breeze, a dense, evergreen buffer protecting the interior from the sea's breath.

Where to see it: Walk the dunes of **Cayo Costa State Park** to see where the saw palmetto meets the sea.

Coastal Berm A ridge of loose shell and debris cast up by the violence of storms, now a quiet refuge for tropical shrubs. It is a testament to the ocean's power to create new land, offering a foothold for life just above the reach of the tides.

Where to see it: Explore the shell ridges at **Cayo Costa State Park** or the **Ten Thousand Islands** to the south

Bottomland Forest Situated on the high terraces of the floodplain, this forest exists in the lull between the river's floods. It is a place of transition, where the water recedes enough for a diversity of oaks and pines to stand tall in the rich, alluvial soil.

Where to see it: Wander the high terraces of the river at **Myakka River State Park**.

Xeric Hammock

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